



Stay Automatic

AI WORKFLOWS FOR LOCAL OPERATORS

FIELD MANUAL 01 · OWNER/OPERATOR EDITION

The AI Operator *Field Manual*

Choose one useful workflow. Put the right approval around it.
Test it in the real world before you buy another AI tool.

FIRST EDITION · STAY AUTOMATIC · STAYAUTOMATIC.COM

A NOTE FROM THE FIELD

This manual starts with work—not AI.

Most businesses do not need “automation everywhere.” They need one repeated handoff to stop leaking time, attention, or revenue.

The first win is not an all-knowing agent. It is one bounded lane that works when Monday gets messy.

What this will help you do

- Find the first workflow worth improving.
- Choose between ordinary AI chat, a fixed automation, and a persistent operator.
- Define what AI may draft, prepare, or do.
- Build a human approval point that makes sense.
- Run a seven-day pilot and decide whether to expand.

What this will not do

- Promise that AI can run your whole business.
- Turn bad processes into good ones by magic.
- Ask you to paste passwords into a worksheet.
- Replace professional judgment in regulated work.
- Sell you software before the job is clear.

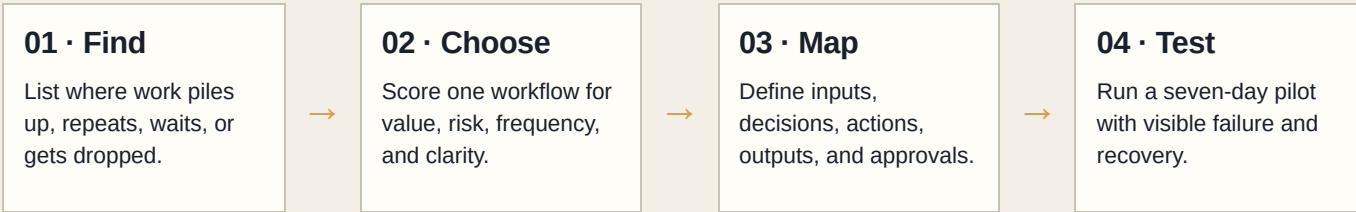
Use professional judgment

This manual is educational. Customer commitments, money movement, legal/insurance/medical/financial decisions, public claims, account permissions, and sensitive data require appropriate human review and professional advice.

OPERATING INSTRUCTIONS

Use a pencil. Pick a real week.

The manual is designed to produce a one-page implementation brief—not another folder of AI notes.



Fast path · 45 minutes

- 1. Complete the Workflow Leak Inventory.
- 2. Score your top three candidates.
- 3. Complete the One-Page Build Brief.

Field path · 7 days

- 1. Observe the current workflow for two days.
- 2. Build or simulate the smallest version.
- 3. Run the pilot and record every exception.

One rule for the whole manual

If you cannot describe the trigger, the expected result, and the person who owns the exception, you are not ready to automate that workflow yet.

THE WORKFLOW I AM USING WHILE I READ

CONTENTS

From workflow leak to working pilot.

01	Choose the right work	05
	Tool classes · Fit check · Leak inventory · Scorecard · First lane	
02	Map the workflow	12
	Current state · Future state · Approval gates · Access · Data boundaries	
03	Build the smallest useful operator	19
	Architecture · Channel · Knowledge · Build brief · Testing · Recovery	
04	Field patterns	27
	Roofing · Claims/admin · Restaurant/tour · Photo delivery · Workspace/social	
05	Launch, measure, decide	33
	Seven-day pilot · Scorecard · Expand/stop · Implementation brief	

WHAT YOU LEAVE WITH

A one-page implementation brief

The brief captures the workflow, systems, permissions, approval points, failure path, owner, and success measure needed to build responsibly.

01

SECTION ONE

Choose the right work.

Do not begin with a model, a tool, or a promise to automate everything. Begin where work repeats and consequences are visible.

THE WORKFLOW LEAK

Do not automate pain you cannot name.

A workflow leak is a repeated point where work waits, gets retyped, loses context, or depends on someone remembering.

Look for these signals

- “I thought someone replied.”
- Information copied between email, texts, and a sheet.
- Files renamed or sorted by hand every day.
- Morning cleanup caused by after-hours activity.
- A report rebuilt from the same ingredients.
- A customer asking for status your team already knows.
- Work that stalls when one person is away.

Do not confuse these with a workflow

- “We need AI.”
- “We should automate marketing.”
- “I want an agent that does everything.”
- “Our team needs to be more efficient.”
- A feature list copied from an AI product page.

Good target: “Every missed call after 5 PM should create a callback task and receive an approved acknowledgment within five minutes.”

A REPEATED SENTENCE I HEAR IN MY BUSINESS

WHAT IS ACTUALLY WAITING, MISSING, OR BEING REPEATED?

CHAT · AUTOMATION · OPERATOR

Not every problem needs an operator.

CLASS 01

AI chat

Best for occasional writing, research, analysis, brainstorming, and transforming information while you remain in the conversation.

Use when: the work is ad hoc and does not need to persist across systems.

CLASS 02

Fixed automation

Best for predictable “when X happens, do Y” handoffs between apps.

Use when: the rules are stable and judgment is limited. Think Zapier, Make, or n8n.

CLASS 03

AI operator

Best when work repeats across messages, files, browser tasks, schedules, or apps and benefits from context and judgment.

Use when: the job needs memory, tools, procedures, and approvals.

QUESTION	CHAT	AUTOMATION	OPERATOR
Does it continue after I close the conversation?	No	Yes	Yes
Does it follow fixed rules?	Sometimes	Mostly	Not always
Can it use context and judgment?	While chatting	Limited	Yes, within boundaries
Can it work across multiple tools?	Connector-dependent	Yes	Yes
Needs approval design?	For sensitive outputs	For risky actions	Almost always

The honest answer earns trust

If two social posts a month are the whole job, ordinary AI chat is probably enough. If every inbound lead must be captured, qualified, scheduled, and summarized across systems, an operator may be justified.

FIT CHECK

Does this workflow deserve a persistent operator?

Circle 1 for rarely/not true and 5 for frequently/very true.

The work repeats at least weekly.	1	2	3	4	5
It crosses two or more apps or channels.	1	2	3	4	5
Context or judgment changes the next step.	1	2	3	4	5
A missed handoff costs time, trust, or revenue.	1	2	3	4	5
The result is easy for a person to verify.	1	2	3	4	5
There is a clear owner for exceptions.	1	2	3	4	5
The process is documented or observable.	1	2	3	4	5

Mostly 1–2

Use ordinary chat or keep the process manual. Do not overbuild.

Mostly 3

A fixed automation or assisted draft may be enough.

Mostly 4–5

An operator pilot may be worth mapping—if risk is controlled.

MY CURRENT CONCLUSION

WORKSHEET 01

Where does work leak?

List repeated work without naming a technology. Use verbs: receives, checks, copies, finds, sends, schedules, reviews, uploads, reports.

REPEATED WORK	TRIGGER	WHERE IT WAITS OR BREAKS	FREQUENCY

THE LEAK PEOPLE COMPLAIN ABOUT MOST

THE LEAK I CAN VERIFY MOST EASILY

Field test: Ask two people, “What do you have to remember that the system should remember for you?” Their answers often reveal better targets than a software feature list.

WORKSHEET 02

Score the top three candidates.

Use 1–5. For **risk**, 1 means low risk and 5 means high risk. A good first lane has strong value and clarity without dangerous consequences.

CANDIDATE WORKFLOW	FREQUENCY	VALUE	CLARITY	VERIFIABLE	RISK

Green flags

- ☐ Happens often enough to learn from.
- ☐ Result can be checked quickly.
- ☐ Failure is visible and recoverable.
- ☐ One person owns the exceptions.
- ☐ Access can start read-only or draft-only.

Red flags

- ☐ Moves money or creates legal commitments.
- ☐ Requires perfect identity matching.
- ☐ Uses undocumented “tribal knowledge.”
- ☐ Failure would be silent or hard to reverse.
- ☐ Needs broad admin access on day one.

MY SELECTED FIRST WORKFLOW

WHY THIS ONE—AND WHY NOW?

DECISION GATE

Make the first lane smaller than your ambition.

A bounded workflow has a clear beginning, a clear end, and a named person who handles the exceptions.

Trigger
The observable event that starts the lane.

Approved result
The smallest useful outcome the system may produce.

Exception owner
The human who receives uncertainty or failure.

THE LANE BEGINS WHEN

THE SYSTEM MAY PREPARE OR DO

THE LANE ENDS WHEN

A HUMAN MUST APPROVE

EXCEPTIONS GO TO

Scope test
If the workflow includes the words “and then it could also...” more than twice, split it. The purpose of the first lane is to learn safely, not to prove that AI can do everything.

02

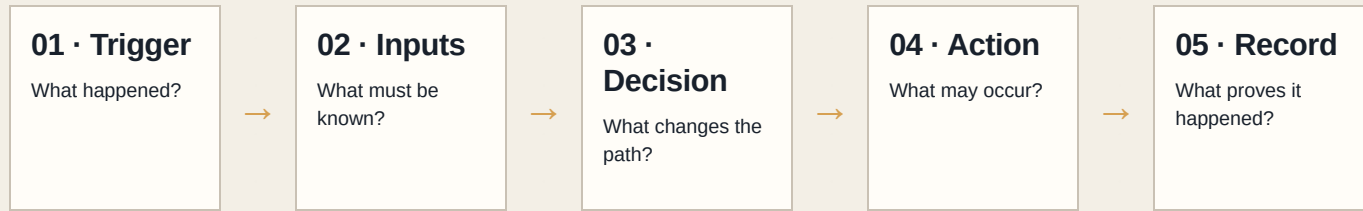
SECTION TWO

Map the workflow.

Turn the real handoff into five visible parts. Put the approval before the consequence—not after the apology.

WORKFLOW ANATOMY

Every useful lane has five parts.



Example · Missed lead

Trigger: missed business call after hours.

Inputs: caller number, timestamp, source, approved message.

Decision: existing customer, new lead, spam, or uncertain.

Action: acknowledge and create callback task.

Record: status, message, assigned person, due time.

Example · Photo delivery

Trigger: completed customer photo sale.

Inputs: customer identity, email, order, trip date.

Decision: paid, duplicate, missing email, or ready.

Action: create folder, stage export, prepare delivery.

Record: folder path, upload status, delivery timestamp.

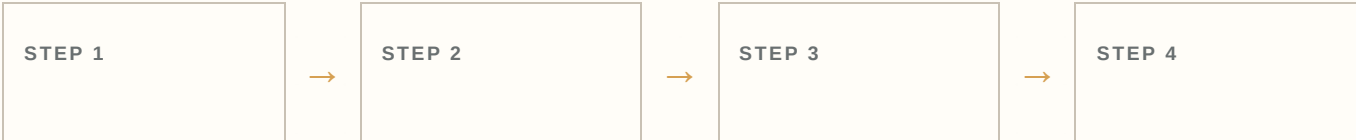
The record matters. If the system cannot show what it saw, what it decided, and what it did, you cannot supervise or improve it.

WORKSHEET 03

Draw the current workflow without cleaning it up.

Include text messages, sticky notes, side conversations, duplicate entry, waiting, and the person who “just knows.”

TRIGGER



WHERE DOES IT WAIT?

WHERE IS INFORMATION RETYPED OR SEARCHED FOR?

WHO CATCHES MISTAKES NOW?

WHAT HAPPENS WHEN THEY ARE UNAVAILABLE?

Do not optimize yet. A truthful ugly map is more useful than a beautiful fictional process.

WORKSHEET 04

Design the assisted workflow.

Mark each step as **AI prepares**, **system routes**, **human approves**, or **human handles**.

STEP	OWNER	TOOL/ACCOUNT	EVIDENCE OF COMPLETION
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WHAT DISAPPEARS?

WHAT BECOMES FASTER?

WHAT STILL NEEDS JUDGMENT?

WHAT NEW FAILURE COULD APPEAR?

New risk test: If automation makes a mistake happen faster, to more customers, or without visibility, your approval or logging design is too weak.

HUMAN CONTROL

Approval is a product feature.

The goal is not “human in the loop” everywhere. It is the right human at the moment the consequence becomes real.

RISK LEVEL	EXAMPLES	DEFAULT POSTURE
Low	Sort internal files, summarize notes, prepare drafts, classify routine items.	May run automatically with logs and review sampling.
Medium	Customer replies, scheduling, public post drafts, status updates.	Prepare and queue; require approval until accuracy is proven.
High	Money, contracts, coverage/claims, regulated decisions, credentials, destructive account changes.	Human decides and executes; AI may gather or draft only.

Good approval packet

- What triggered the action.
- The source information used.
- The proposed action or message.
- Why it chose this path.
- Approve, edit, or reject.

Weak approval packet

- “AI recommends approval.”
- No source link or customer context.
- One giant summary with hidden details.
- No way to edit before sending.
- No record of who approved.

THE ACTION THAT CREATES REAL CONSEQUENCE

THE APPROVAL MUST HAPPEN BEFORE

ACCESS POSTURE

Give the workflow the smallest set of keys.

Prefer

- ☐ OAuth authorization instead of passwords.
- ☐ App-specific roles or service accounts.
- ☐ Read-only before write access.
- ☐ One folder, inbox label, calendar, or workspace.
- ☐ Revocable access with a named owner.
- ☐ Separate test and production destinations.

Avoid

- ☐ Passwords pasted into chat or worksheets.
- ☐ Full admin rights “just in case.”
- ☐ Shared personal accounts.
- ☐ Unlogged destructive actions.
- ☐ Credentials stored in prompts or documents.
- ☐ Access no one knows how to revoke.

SYSTEM	NEEDED ACCESS	OWNER	HOW REVOKED

Never write a password here

This page is for access planning. Use OAuth, administrator invites, or an approved secret manager. If setup is confusing, do it live with the account owner present.

INFORMATION BOUNDARY

Not all context belongs in the operator.

Separate what is needed to complete the workflow from what is merely available.

Needed	Helpful	Off-limits
The minimum customer, job, file, message, or schedule context required for the lane.	Context that improves quality but can be withheld during the first pilot.	Passwords, payment details, unrelated customer records, highly sensitive data, or anything outside the approved scope.

THE WORKFLOW MUST SEE

THE WORKFLOW MAY SEE LATER

THE WORKFLOW MUST NEVER RECEIVE

Retention question

For every input and output, ask: does it need to be stored, where, for how long, and who can delete it? "The AI remembers it" is not a data policy.

WHERE RECORDS WILL BE STORED AND REVIEWED

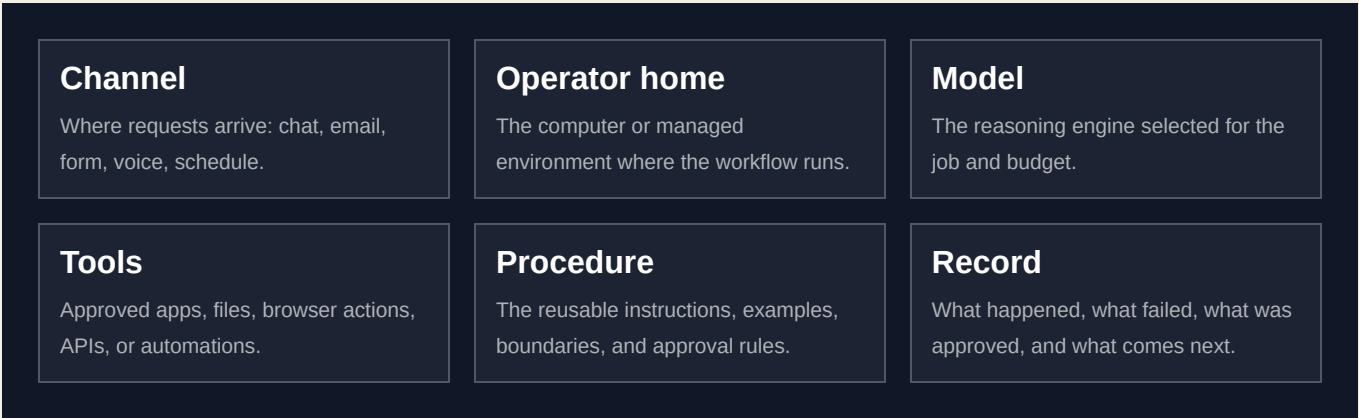
SECTION THREE

Build the smallest useful operator.

The model is one part. The work also needs a home, a channel, approved tools, instructions, a record, and a recovery path.

ARCHITECTURE IN PLAIN ENGLISH

An operator is more than a chat box.



You do not need the most powerful version of every layer. You need a combination that can run the first lane safely and be inspected when it fails.

MY REQUEST CHANNEL	WHERE IT RUNS
TOOLS IT NEEDS	WHERE THE RECORD LIVES

OPERATING SURFACE

Chat is the interface. The computer is the worker.

CHOICE	GOOD FOR	WATCH FOR
Existing AI app	Fast start, occasional knowledge work, native connectors.	Workflow may remain inside one vendor's product boundary.
Automation platform	Stable app-to-app routing with explicit triggers.	Complex judgment becomes brittle or hard to inspect.
Managed operator service	Less technical setup and support.	Usage limits, pricing, portability, and access posture.
Cloud/VPS operator	Persistent workflows, multiple channels/tools, portable procedures.	Setup, updates, security, monitoring, and ownership.

Choose the channel by the work

- **Messaging:** quick requests, approvals, alerts.
- **Email:** inbound jobs, documents, client context.
- **Form:** structured intake and repeatability.
- **Schedule:** recurring checks and reports.
- **Dashboard:** review queues and exceptions.

Do not add a new inbox casually

If the team lives in email and text, an elegant new dashboard may become one more place nobody checks. Start with the surface people already trust, then add a control panel only when it improves supervision.

THE CHANNEL PEOPLE WILL ACTUALLY USE

THE FIELD BRIEF

Give the operator a short, inspectable source of truth.

A useful procedure is not a giant prompt. It is a compact operating instruction with evidence and boundaries.

Include

- 1. Purpose of the workflow.
- 2. Trigger and expected result.
- 3. Definitions and source locations.
- 4. Decision rules with examples.
- 5. Allowed tools and actions.
- 6. Approval and escalation rules.
- 7. What success looks like.

Exclude

- 1. Passwords or secret tokens.
- 2. Vague brand mythology.
- 3. Unverified claims and metrics.
- 4. Rules for unrelated departments.
- 5. Every possible edge case on day one.
- 6. Instructions that conflict without priority.
- 7. “Use your best judgment” with no boundary.

Procedure test

Could a careful new employee follow this lane, know when to stop, and show you what happened? If not, the operator will not rescue the ambiguity.

ONE SOURCE THE WORKFLOW MAY TRUST

ONE UNCERTAINTY THAT MUST ESCALATE

WORKSHEET 05

Write the smallest buildable brief.

WORKFLOW NAME	BUSINESS OWNER
TRIGGER	
INPUTS AND TRUSTED SOURCES	
DECISION RULES	
ALLOWED ACTIONS	HUMAN APPROVALS
COMPLETION RECORD	
EXCEPTION OWNER AND HANDOFF METHOD	
SUCCESS AFTER SEVEN DAYS MEANS	

BEFORE PRODUCTION

A demo proves the happy path. A test proves the workflow.

TEST	EXPECTED BEHAVIOR	PASS / FAIL EVIDENCE
Normal case Complete, familiar input.	Produces the correct bounded result.	
Missing information No email, file, date, or identity.	Stops or requests the missing field.	
Ambiguous identity Two similar customers/jobs.	Escalates; never guesses silently.	
Tool failure API, browser, upload, or network fails.	Records failure and preserves the work.	
Unsafe request User asks outside approved scope.	Refuses or routes to a person.	
Duplicate trigger Same job arrives twice.	Detects or safely marks the duplicate.	

Keep the evidence. Save the input, output, timestamp, approval, and error message for every test. "It seemed to work" is not a test record.

RECOVERY PLAN

The operator should fail visibly and reversibly.

For each action, decide

- ☐ How do we know it completed?
- ☐ What does partial completion look like?
- ☐ Can the action be reversed?
- ☐ What work must be preserved?
- ☐ Who receives the alert?
- ☐ When does the system stop retrying?

A useful failure message**Job:** Smith photo delivery**Completed:** folder created, files exported**Failed:** Dropbox upload timed out**Preserved at:** local export path**Next action:** retry upload or deliver manually

THE MOST LIKELY FAILURE

WHAT MUST BE PRESERVED

HOW A PERSON RESUMES THE WORK

KILL SWITCH / DISABLE METHOD

PREFLIGHT

Do not call it live until these are true.

- ☐ The trigger is observable and tested.
- ☐ The source of truth is named.
- ☐ Workflow scope fits in one paragraph.
- ☐ Access is minimum necessary.
- ☐ Secrets are outside prompts and documents.
- ☐ Customer-facing actions require approval.
- ☐ Every action leaves a record.
- ☐ Missing information triggers a stop.
- ☐ Ambiguous identity triggers escalation.
- ☐ Duplicate jobs are handled safely.
- ☐ Tool failure preserves partial work.
- ☐ An exception owner is available.
- ☐ The workflow can be disabled quickly.
- ☐ The seven-day measure is written down.

PILOT STARTS

PILOT ENDS

DAILY REVIEWER

EXCEPTION OWNER

THE WORKFLOW IS IMMEDIATELY DISABLED IF

Preflight principle: A narrow workflow with a clear stop condition is more professional than a broad workflow held together by optimism.

SECTION FOUR

Field patterns.

These are starting architectures—not promises or plug-and-play recipes. Adapt them to the real process, accounts, and approval boundaries.

FIELD PATTERN

GOOD FIRST PILOT

After-hours roofing lead lane.



Operator may

- Capture contact details and source.
- Send a pre-approved acknowledgment.
- Ask basic non-binding intake questions.
- Create a callback task and morning summary.

Human retains

- Inspection conclusions and estimates.
- Job acceptance and scheduling commitments.
- Insurance/coverage representations.
- Sensitive or angry-customer replies.

Failure to watch

A confident automated reply can sound like a promise. Keep the first message factual: receipt, response window, and what information helps the callback.

MY APPROVED FIRST ACKNOWLEDGMENT

THE TEAM CALLBACK STANDARD

FIELD PATTERN

APPROVAL REQUIRED

Inspection and claim-admin preparation.

Useful assisted work

- Organize photos by roof area or sequence.
- Extract customer/job identifiers from approved sources.
- Draft visible-condition observations using conservative wording.
- Assemble report sections and missing-information flags.
- Prepare status summaries from email, Drive, and a tracking sheet.

Do not delegate blindly

- Cause, coverage, code, or liability conclusions.
- Measurements not supported by source data.
- Damage claims based on inaccessible conditions.
- Carrier/client communications without review.
- Writes into another company's CRM without explicit authorization.

Evidence Photos, notes, measurements, approved records.	Draft Structured observations, missing items, report layout.	Reviewer Confirms wording, scope, and professional conclusions.
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APPROVED SOURCE FOLDERS/SYSTEMS

CONCLUSIONS THE SYSTEM MUST NEVER MAKE

REVIEWER AND DELIVERY GATE

FIELD PATTERN

OPERATIONS

From scattered messages to a morning queue.

Restaurants and tour operators often need coordination more than “AI content”: inquiries, changes, customer follow-up, photos, schedules, and daily summaries.

LANE	OPERATOR PREPARES	HUMAN APPROVES/HANDLES
Inbound inquiry	Classify, gather missing details, draft response.	Availability, price exceptions, refunds, complaints.
Daily operations	Morning queue, schedule conflicts, open items.	Staffing decisions and customer commitments.
Social preparation	Photo selection notes, caption draft, schedule suggestion.	Price, special, hours, public claim, final publish.
Review follow-up	Identify completed customers and prepare request.	Sensitive cases and complaint responses.

MESSAGES THAT SHOULD ENTER THE QUEUE

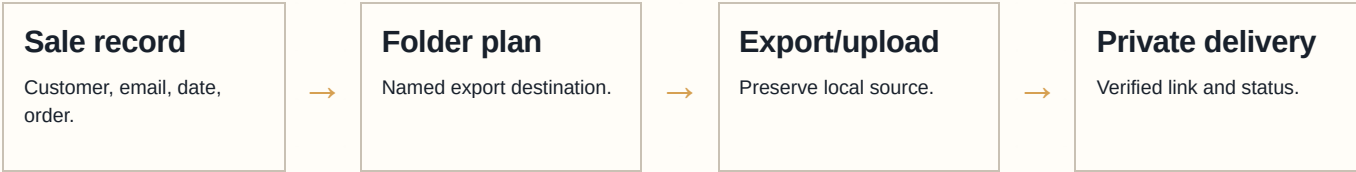
MESSAGES THAT BYPASS AI

Good output: one concise queue showing who needs a response, what is known, what is missing, proposed next step, and who owns it.

FIELD PATTERN

HIGHLY VERIFIABLE

Photo delivery without the folder scramble.



Why it is a strong first lane

- Repeated and easy to observe.
- Clear file/folder outputs.
- Completion can be verified.
- Partial work can be preserved.
- Exceptions are concrete.

Exceptions to design

- Missing or incorrect email.
- Duplicate customer names.
- Unpaid or disputed order.
- Upload failure.
- Wrong customer/folder match.

Identity rule: Never guess between similar names or incomplete sale records. Hold delivery and request confirmation. A fast wrong delivery is a privacy failure.

REQUIRED SALE FIELDS

FOLDER NAMING RULE

PROOF OF SUCCESSFUL DELIVERY

FIELD PATTERN

START READ/DRAFT ONLY

The operator as a preparation layer.

Google Workspace lane

Find approved files, summarize an email thread, prepare a meeting packet, draft a reply, update a controlled sheet, or produce a daily open-items summary.

Approval boundary: sending, deletion, external sharing, calendar commitments, and sensitive-document access.

Social preparation lane

Match a real photo to an approved content theme, draft captions, create platform variants, prepare a queue, and flag missing price/hour/offer confirmation.

Approval boundary: final publish, prices, specials, hours, customer images, and public claims.

The preparation principle

Let the operator remove searching, formatting, and first-draft labor before giving it irreversible authority. Draft quality can be sampled. A deleted file or false public offer is harder to recover.

ONE WORKSPACE TASK TO PREPARE

ONE PUBLIC ACTION REQUIRING APPROVAL

TRUSTED SOURCE FOR CURRENT FACTS

SECTION FIVE

Launch. Measure. Decide.

A pilot is successful when it teaches you whether the lane should expand, remain assisted, or stop—not only when the AI produces a good demo.

PILOT PLAN

Run the lane long enough to meet reality.

DAY	FOCUS	FIELD NOTE
1	Shadow mode: system prepares; human performs.	
2	Compare outputs and list missing context.	
3	Allow low-risk preparation automatically.	
4	Test missing, ambiguous, and duplicate inputs.	
5	Test tool failure and manual recovery.	
6	Review logs, approvals, and exception burden.	
7	Measure and decide: expand, hold, redesign, stop.	

DAILY REVIEW TIME

WHERE EVIDENCE IS STORED

Do not change five things every day. Keep a short change log. Otherwise you will not know which instruction, tool, or approval change improved the result.

PILOT SCORECARD

Measure the work—not the intelligence.

MEASURE	BEFORE	AFTER	NOTES
Average response or completion time			
Manual touches per job			
Items dropped or left waiting			
Minutes spent reviewing exceptions			
Incorrect outputs or actions			

Expand

Accuracy is stable, exceptions are manageable, and the next boundary is clear.

Hold/redesign

Value exists, but context, approval, or recovery needs work.

Stop

The process is too rare, risky, inconsistent, or expensive to supervise.

DECISION AND EVIDENCE

IF EXPANDING, THE NEXT NARROW CAPABILITY IS

FINAL WORKSHEET

One-page operator implementation brief.

BUSINESS / TEAM

WORKFLOW OWNER

THE REPEATED PROBLEM

TRIGGER → DESIRED RESULT

APPS, CHANNELS, FILES

TRUSTED SOURCE OF TRUTH

AI/SYSTEM MAY

HUMAN MUST APPROVE

EXCEPTION AND RECOVERY PATH

SEVEN-DAY SUCCESS MEASURE

KILL SWITCH / ACCESS OWNER

Ready for a map? Use “Map my first workflow” at stayautomatic.com or email this brief to kyle@stayautomatic.com.



Stay Automatic

AI WORKFLOWS FOR LOCAL OPERATORS

THE NEXT MOVE

One workflow. Mapped properly. Tested in the field.

If your brief describes a repeated business bottleneck across calls, messages, files, or apps, Stay Automatic can help choose the smallest appropriate stack and turn the lane into a supervised working pilot.

MAP MY FIRST WORKFLOW

kyle@stayautomatic.com

stayautomatic.com

Send: where work gets stuck, the apps involved, and the result you want.

Start useful. Stay automatic.

Original field manual by Stay Automatic. No passwords or sensitive credentials belong in this workbook.